

Interview Transcripts

Field research conducted January 2026

Client	Generation Bridge Foundation
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The following transcripts have been lightly edited for length and clarity. Speaker names are shown in bold. The interviewer is a member of the engagement team. Cite these conversations by their reference code, for example (ST-01).

ST-01 - Hung Vo, Programmes Director

Interviewer: What worries you most right now?

Hung: Honestly, we are succeeding ourselves into a crisis. There are 2,400 young people on the waitlist. Families call us in tears. And my field team in Dong Nai is working sixty-hour weeks because we will not hire until the Board decides on a strategy.

Interviewer: Tell me about Dong Nai.

Hung: Transport, mostly. The young people commute a long way to industrial zones and pay 150 to 200 thousand dong a month for buses that we do not cover. Internship drop-out hit 38 per cent last quarter. Anh Duc wanted to report 'completion' instead of 'internship completion' to make it look better. I refused.

Interviewer: Should GBF expand to Long An?

Hung: Not until Dong Nai works. The Long An pilot lost about 60 per cent of its young people. There is a board member pushing Long An for reasons that have more to do with his own contacts than with strategy.

Interviewer: And Pathway Digital?

Hung: It is cheaper per head, yes. But the real completion rate is 52 per cent, not the 68 we reported. The digital team counted enrolments, not people who actually finished. I have asked them to correct it.

Interviewer: If you could get one thing from this review?

Hung: Permission to pause expansion and fix quality. Even if a couple of bad employers complain to the Board.

ST-02 - Thao Le, Operations Director

Interviewer: Is the 71 per cent placement rate accurate?

Thao: It depends what you mean by placed. If you include gig work at fifteen hours a week, yes. If you mean a formal contract, it is closer to 63 per cent. VPBank knows we use the broader definition.

Interviewer: What does it cost to serve one young person?

Thao: Skills Forward is about 12.8 million dong per completer including staff time. Pathway Digital is about 6.2 million, but its placement rate is lower.

Interviewer: Can GBF reach 4,000 young people by 2028?

Thao: Only with the VPBank money and roughly 25 more staff. And recruitment is hard - we lose people to factory HR jobs and to YouthWorks. Turnover was 34 per cent.

Interviewer: The Executive Director has mentioned an intake chatbot.

Thao: I think it is a distraction. Our young people need a human voice on the phone, not a chatbot that cannot understand a Mekong Delta accent.

ST-03 - Linh Nguyen, Monitoring & Evaluation Officer

Interviewer: How reliable is your data?

Linh: Frankly, it is a mess. We have duplicate beneficiary IDs, dates in three different formats, and field staff

who mark someone as placed after a single ride-hailing shift. There are four of us covering 2,800 young people.

Interviewer: Anything specific we should check?

Linh: Look at the Dong Nai costs for the third quarter - I think a month was entered twice. And there is at least one wage figure that is obviously a typo.

Interviewer: What about young people with disabilities?

Linh: We report six per cent of our beneficiaries have a disability. The population figure is nearer nine. And their placement rate is about 49 per cent against 71 overall. Donors never see that breakdown.

ST-04 - Anh Duc Pham, Development Director

Interviewer: How serious is the YouthWorks threat?

Anh Duc: Overstated. They have no internship. Our outcomes are better. Yes, they are free and we take longer, but young people who want a real job come to us.

Interviewer: And the VPBank offer?

Anh Duc: It is the opportunity of a decade. Eight billion dong if we hit 65 per cent and scale. We should commit publicly. Hesitation kills donor confidence.

Interviewer: Some staff have raised reporting placement at sixty days.

Anh Duc: That is industry practice. When an outcome is probable, you can measure it early. M&E is being precious about it.

ST-05 - Minh Tran, Field Officer, Dong Nai

Interviewer: Describe your caseload.

Minh: There are four of us for about 120 young people. Policy says we visit every employer monthly. That is simply not possible.

Interviewer: You mentioned employer problems.

Minh: Two employers on our partner list exploit the interns - ten-hour days, no real duties. I reported them months ago. Nothing happened.

Interviewer: Is YouthWorks affecting you?

Minh: Last month they took about fifteen young people off our waitlist in the border districts. And I will tell you something we modelled quietly: a transport stipend of 100 thousand dong a month would roughly halve our drop-out.

BN-01 - Mai, Programme graduate, Ho Chi Minh City

Interviewer: How did you find the programme?

Mai: I waited five months for a place and almost gave up. The training was good - I learned Excel and customer service. The internship was far from home, though, about 170 thousand dong a month in bus fares that I paid myself.

Interviewer: Did you get a job?

Mai: Yes, at the same logistics company, a real contract, 5.8 million dong a month. I was lucky. My friend in the Dong Nai group quit because the employer made them work ten-hour days for nothing.

Interviewer: Would Pathway Digital have suited you?

Mai: No. I do not have a laptop and my phone is old. Skills Forward was right for me.

BN-02 - Tuan, Withdrew from the programme, Dong Nai

Interviewer: Why did you leave?

Tuan: The training was fine. The internship was miserable - no contract, ten-hour days, and the boss told us to be grateful. My mother is ill and I could not afford the buses and lose time at her coffee stall.

Interviewer: What would have kept you in?

Tuan: Employers who respect us, and some help with transport. GBF never checked the workplace before

they sent us. People in meetings talk about numbers. Nobody asked me what the bus cost or what the boss said when I asked for a contract. I still want a factory job with proper insurance.

BN-03 - Lan, Graduate with a disability, Ho Chi Minh City

Interviewer: Was the programme accessible?

Lan: The building had no ramp at first; they moved the class downstairs after I complained. My mentor was kind but did not know much about disability employment rights.

Interviewer: How is the job search?

Lan: Still looking after four months. Employers say they will call and they do not. GBF counts me as 'in progress'. I feel like a statistic.

BN-04 - Hang, On the waitlist, Binh Duong

Interviewer: How long have you been waiting?

Hang: Seven months. YouthWorks offered me a six-week course, but there was no internship, so I stayed on the GBF list. I will take whichever one gets me a real job with social insurance.

DN-01 - Ms. Huong, Programme Officer, VPBank Foundation

Interviewer: What do you need to see to renew?

Huong: Three things: a placement rate of 65 per cent at ninety days, a credible path to 4,000 young people by 2028, and a monitoring framework we can trust.

Interviewer: Does gig work count?

Huong: If it is stable and at least fifteen hours a week, yes. But we would prefer formal employment reported separately.

Interviewer: What if GBF asked to slow down and fix quality first?

Huong: We would listen. We could consider a smaller, quality-focused grant. But the Board would need to bring us a credible theory of change, not simply 'give us time'. Other organisations are competing for this money.

Interviewer: And sixty-day reporting?

Huong: Ninety days is the contract. Early figures are supplementary, nothing more.

EP-01 - Mr. Khang, HR Manager, gold-tier employer partner

Interviewer: How do the GBF interns perform?

Khang: Mixed. The best are excellent - we hired twelve last year. The weakest lack basic punctuality. GBF prepares them on soft skills but not on factory discipline.

Interviewer: Would you take more?

Khang: If they were better pre-screened. We get too many who want an office job, not logistics. And, frankly, it is awkward that GBF Staffing Solutions then charges us a fee to hire them permanently.

EP-02 - Ms. Trang, Operations manager, logistics subcontractor (anonymous)

Interviewer: How does your firm use GBF interns?

Trang: Look, I will be straight with you. We are short-staffed in peak season. The interns help with sorting and packing. We pay the legal minimum stipend but the work is repetitive and the hours are long. GBF visited once at the start and we have not seen a caseworker since. I am not proud of it, but if they stopped sending people we would manage.

Interviewer: Would you take more interns?

Trang: Only if someone actually checked that we were treating them properly.

VR-01 - Chi Hoa, Volunteer mentor, three years

Interviewer: Is the mentoring model sustainable?

Hoa: Volunteers burn out. I mentor four young people, which is too many. We get a two-hour orientation and then we are on our own.

Interviewer: Could volunteers replace paid field staff?

Hoà: No. Absolutely not. I have dealt with domestic violence, debt, and a young person at risk of suicide. That needs a professional. Volunteers support the work; we cannot be the work.

BD-01 - Mr. T.N., Member of the GBF Board

Interviewer: Where do you stand on strategy?

T.N.: We must accept the VPBank money and scale to Long An. I have political support lined up. If we hesitate, we lose momentum and we lose donors. The 'pause and fix' talk worries me.